

Previous Years' Questions

1. What are the maritime security challenges in India? Discuss the organisational, technical and procedural initiatives taken to improve the maritime security. (2022)
2. For effective border area management, discuss the steps required to be taken to deny local support to militants and also suggest ways to manage favourable perception among locals. (2020)
3. Analyze internal security threats and transborder crimes along Myanmar, Bangladesh and Pakistan borders including Line of Control (LoC). Also discuss the role played by various security forces in this regard. (2020)
4. Cross-border movement of insurgents is only one of the several security challenges facing the policing of the border in North-East India. Examine the various challenges currently emanating across the India-Myanmar border. Also, discuss the steps to counter the challenges. (2019)
5. The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is viewed as a cardinal subset of China's larger 'One Belt One Road' initiative. Give a brief description of CPEC and enumerate the reasons why India has distanced itself from the same. (2018)
6. The north-eastern region of India has been infested with insurgency for a very long time. Analyze the major reasons for the survival of armed insurgency in this region. (2017)
7. Border management is a complex task due to difficult terrain and hostile relations with some countries. Elucidate the challenges and strategies for effective border management. (2016)
8. Human rights activists constantly highlight the view that the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA) is a draconian act leading to cases of human rights abuses by the security forces. What sections of AFSPA are opposed by the activists? Critically evaluate the requirement with reference to the view held by the Apex Court. (2015)
9. How illegal transborder migration does pose a threat to India's security? Discuss the strategies to curb this, bring out the factors which give impetus to such migration. (2014)
10. In 2012, the longitudinal marking of the high-risk areas for piracy was moved from 65° East to 78° east in the Arabian Sea by International Maritime organisation. What impact does this have on India's maritime security concerns? (2014)
11. China and Pakistan have entered into an agreement for development of an economic corridor. What thread does it dispose for India's security? Critically examine. (2014)
12. How far are India's internal security challenges linked with border management, particularly in view of the long porous borders with most countries of South Asia and Myanmar? (2013)

Territorial Border Security

India has 15,106.7 Km of land border and a coastline of 7,516.6 Km including island territories. According to the **UNSC counter-terrorism committee**, border management is the first line of defence against the movement of terrorists across borders and the illegal cross-border movement of goods and cargo.

Afghanistan-(106 KM): India's border with Afghanistan falls in Pakistan occupied Kashmir. Thus, presently there is no movement across the border between India and Afghanistan. India has to depend either on Pakistan or on Iran for reaching up to Afghanistan.

Bhutan (699 KM): Most cordial relations among all neighbours. There are no border disputes. India and Bhutan collaborated to eliminate ULFA extremists. However, Chinese activities across Chumbi valley and the Doklam region (disputed between China and Bhutan) can be a challenge since the plateau directly overlooks the 'chicken neck' connecting mainland India with the north-east.

Bangladesh (4156 KM): Longest border with any neighbour. The border dispute has been settled with the signing of **Land Boundary Agreement** and **exchange of enclaves**. Most challenging border to manage because of **dense forests, rivers crisscrossing both nations** and **rough terrain**. Students' protest and the subsequent regime change in Bangladesh has further created challenges along the India-Bangladesh border.

Common threats and crimes:

1. **Frequent Illegal migration** has resulted in demographic inversion in bordering states like Tripura, Assam, and West Bengal.
2. **Human and cattle trafficking** giving rise to organised crime networks.
3. Used to supply material support in the form of weapons, cash etc. to the **Left-Wing Extremists** and insurgent groups of North-East.
4. Used for pushing in fake currency, and smuggling gold and narcotics in India.
5. Porous borders used by the ISI and other radical groups within Bangladesh to foment trouble in India through terrorists.

India and Bangladesh have agreed to effectively implement the **Comprehensive Border Management Plan (CBMP)** to control border crimes.

China (3488 KM): Except for central sector, both western and eastern sectors remain disputed with China laying claim over Aksai Chin in the western sector and Arunachal Pradesh in the eastern sector. Absence of clear demarcation results in frequent incursions by China. This has led to decline in bilateral cooperation and has accentuated mutual animosity.

Common Threats:

1. China doing frequent border incursions since the most of border remain undermarketed. Incursions have resulted in recent disputes over Doklam Plateau and in Galwan Valley.
2. There have been reports about China supporting radical groups like ULFA.
3. Illegal imports across the border from China leads to loss of taxes and renders Indian companies uncompetitive.

4. China has taken benefit of the undermarketed border and has gone for salami-slicing technique with slow encroachment over Indian territory.
5. Increased military deployments in the border region cause inconvenience to locals as restrictions are put on their movement, grazing areas etc.

Myanmar (1643 KM): India and Myanmar share 1,643 km unfenced border along four states viz. Arunachal Pradesh (520 km), Nagaland (215 km), Manipur (398 km) and Mizoram (510 km). Both sides permitted **Free Movement Regime (FMR) up to 16 km beyond border**. This coupled with dense forests makes effective border management extremely difficult. Secessionist Groups **NSCN (K), ULFA** etc. take advantage of the porous border to launch attack on Indian forces and run away to the other side of the border. E.g.- Attack on Dogra Regiment in Manipur in 2015.

This border is **also used by China to support the insurgent groups**. Indian and Myanmar armies have cooperated to neutralise these extremist groups on their respective sides of the border through **Operation Sunrise**. With coup in Myanmar and coming of military junta, **refugee crisis** has emerged as a new challenge, putting pressure on small North Eastern states. This also has potential to dampen the relationships with Myanmar.

Both national governments agreed to conduct a joint survey before erecting the fence. The Indian Home Ministry and its Myanmar counterpart completed the study within six months and, in March 2003 began erecting a fence along the border. In 2004, fencing work in the state of Manipur along the border was stalled due to protests raised by the local Kuki and Naga communities. According to them, a huge stretch of land would become Myanmar's territory and foster unrest among people living on both sides of the border. This fence will divide many ethnic communities, including the Mizo, Nagas, Chins, and Kukis whose lands straddle the regions between the two states- it is thus a highly sensitive issue.

The fencing has been started again. Manipur Chief Minister in May 2022 said that centre has approved construction of 100 Km fencing along Manipur's India-Myanmar border. Village chiefs of the area have declared full support to state government's "War on Drugs" and efforts to eradicate poppy plantation from the area.

Free Movement Regime (FMR): FMR was bilateral agreement between India and Myanmar that allows free movement of Indian and Myanmar citizens within 16 km of the border without visa restrictions for 72 hours. Its purpose is to alleviate insecurity of tribals living along India and Myanmar border as they still continue to have trans-border linkages with their kith and kins.

Common Threats:

1. Free movement regime is being misused by militants and trans-border criminals to smuggle weapons, contraband goods, and fake Indian currency notes.
2. Groups like NSCN (K), ULFA have their camps in Myanmar. They easily cross border and attack on the security forces.
3. Myanmar being part of **Golden Triangle**, narcotics trade across the border has remained a key concern.
4. Illegal imports from Myanmar to Indian markets.
5. The border has also been used by China to support insurgent groups in India.

6. It has also led to influx of refugees after military coup in Myanmar.

Initiative to manage Free Movement Regime:

- In January 2018, Union Cabinet had approved agreement (Memorandum of Understanding) between India and Myanmar on land border crossing to enhance economic interaction between people of two countries.
- To give it shape, Central Government had asked four border states with Myanmar to distribute “border pass” to all the residents living within 16 km from the border.
- The agreement has been deferred twice.

Myanmar's response:

- Myanmar has indefinitely deferred signing agreement with India to streamline free movement of people within 16 km along open border between two countries.
- It has cited domestic compulsions and has asked for more time for the agreement to be sealed.

Border Pass Proposal

There are over 250 villages with over 300,000 people living within 10 km of border who frequently cross it through 150 small and large, formal, and informal, border crossings. As per proposal, there will be no restrictions on movement of people across borders. But, domiciles across the border will be allotted border passes and those going across for agriculture, work or to meet relatives need to carry pass all times.

In February 2024, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has suspended the Free Movement Regime (FMR) between India and Myanmar to ensure the internal security of the country and to maintain the demographic structure of India's North Eastern States bordering Myanmar. Ministry of External Affairs is in the process of scrapping it. The government has decided to construct a fence along the entire 1643-kilometer-long Indo-Myanmar border. Out of the total border length, a 10 km stretch in Moreh, Manipur, has already been fenced. Furthermore, two pilot projects of fencing through a **Hybrid Surveillance System (HSS)** are under execution.

Nepal (1751 KM): India and Nepal have open borders where citizens of each other's nations do not require visa for going from one country to the other. This has increased people-to-people contacts. Nearly **eight million Nepali citizens live and work in India**.

Currently, India and Nepal have border disputes over Kalapani - Limpiyadhura - Lipulekh trijunction between India-Nepal and China and Susta area (West Champaran district, Bihar). Nepal has released a new political map that claims Kalapani, Limpiyadhura and Lipulekh of Uttarakhand as part of Nepal's territory.

Common Threats:

1. Pakistan uses Nepal as conduit to infiltrate terrorists, and conduct smuggling activities including narcotics.
2. People with fake voter cards, Aadhaar cards are frequently nabbed by security forces with rackets running in Nepal.

3. It is also used by Left Wing Extremist groups for moving from one nation to the other to avoid getting arrested.
4. Instability with in Nepal can also spill over to Indian states of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh due to open borders.
5. There are concerns about demographic changes taking place along the border.

Pakistan (3233 KM): 776 KM is LoC, part of disputed Jammu and Kashmir. Most notorious border with frequent cases of ceasefire violations, cross border infiltrations and launch of terrorists. Hilly terrain, dense forests, high mountains and snow covered passes during the winters makes it very difficult to manage the border. Many a times, cross border tunnels have also been found to push in the terrorists within India.

Even along international border, the maritime boundary along Rann of Kutch remains disputed between two nations.

Common Threats:

1. Disputed portion largely active border with frequent ceasefire violations remains a threat to life and property of civilians living along the border.
2. Infiltration of terrorists through dense forests, steep passes and underground tunnels. Terrorists have also used the maritime route. E.g.- 26/11 Mumbai terror attack.
3. Pakistan's attempt to radicalise the youth through propaganda and providing training to them to carry out attacks in India.
4. Due to disputed maritime border along, Indian fishermen are frequently arrested by Pakistan Army.
5. Arms and narcotics smuggling through land, riverine and maritime border. Prevalence of drugs in Punjab has been linked with cross border trafficking.
6. Use of drones for dropping weapons, explosives and drugs has emerged a new challenge.

Initiatives towards resolution were taken through **Composite Dialogue** to resolve all outstanding issues. However, it could not be successful.

Department of Border Management under Ministry of Home Affairs:

In pursuance of Group of Ministers recommendations on Border Management, the **Department of Border Management** was created in the Ministry of Home Affairs in **January, 2004** to pay focused attention to the issues relating to management of international land and coastal borders, strengthening of border policing & guarding, creation of infrastructure like roads, fencing & flood lighting on the borders and implementation of Border Area Development Programme.

The functions/ responsibilities of Border Management Department:

1. All matters relating to **management of land borders** (excluding LOC in J&K sector).
2. All matters relating to **coastal border** including island territories of Andaman & Nicobar and Lakshadweep, etc. Matters relating to fencing and floodlighting of Indo-Bangladesh and Indo-Pak borders.
3. Strengthening of **border policing, surveillance and patrolling** in all land and coastal borders.

4. **Creation of infrastructure** including construction of motorable roads, provision of communication facilities, etc. in the border belt.
5. **Creation of infrastructure in coastal belt.**
6. **Analysis of intelligence reports** and sharing of actionable intelligence with concerned agencies relating to international borders.
7. MHA's input in regard to **demarcation of international borders.**
8. **Composite strategy** defining **complementary roles of State Governments** and of **the Centre** in border management.
9. All matters relating to implementation of **Border Area Development Programme.**
10. Development of **Integrated Check Posts (ICPs)** on the land borders of the country including setting up of **Land Ports Authority of India (LPAI).**

While addressing the closing session of the two-day National Security Strategies (NSS) Conference, Union Home Minister stressed checking the demographic change in border areas and maintaining strict vigilance.

Steps taken for Border Management

Deployment of Comprehensive Integrated Border Management System (CIBMS):

- Installation of indigenously designed virtual fencing system- **Comprehensive Integrated Border Management System (CIBMS)** Employing latest technology to detect infiltration via land, underwater, air and tunnels.

Comprehensive Integrated Border Management System (CIBMS)

- CIBMS involves deployment of a range of state-of-the-art surveillance technologies — thermal imagers, infra-red and laser-based intruder alarms, aerostats for aerial surveillance, unattended ground sensors that can help detect intrusion bids, radars, sonar systems to secure riverine borders, fibre-optic sensors and a command-and-control system that shall receive data from all surveillance devices in real time.
- It will vastly improve the capability of BSF in detecting and controlling the cross-border crimes like illegal infiltration, smuggling of contraband goods, human trafficking and cross border terrorism etc.
- **Project BOLD-QIT (Border Electronically Dominated QRT Interception Technique)** under Comprehensive Integrated Border Management System (CIBMS) on Indo- Bangladesh border in Dhubri district of Assam has been setup. The aim is to cover the complete border over a period of time.

Continuation of Border Infrastructure and Management (BIM):

- The government has approved a Rs 13,020 crore central sector umbrella scheme for continuation of the **Border Infrastructure and Management (BIM)** during 15th Finance Commission cycle from 2021-22 to 2025-26.
- The BIM scheme will help in the creation of infrastructure such as border fence, border flood lights, technological solutions, border roads and border outposts (BOPs) and company operating bases to secure India's borders with Pakistan, Bangladesh, China, Nepal, Bhutan and Myanmar.

Border Area Development Programme (BADP):

- The **Border Area Development Programme** (BADP) is implemented through the state governments in 396 border blocks of 111 districts in 17 border states.
- BADP is for meeting the special developmental needs and wellbeing of people living in the remote and inaccessible areas situated near the international borders and to saturate the border areas with critical infrastructure and sustainable livelihood opportunities.
- This would help in mainstreaming the border population, integrate the border areas with the hinterland and create conducive environment that would encourage people to stay on in the border areas.

Vibrant Villages Program:

- India's Finance Minister announced the new **Vibrant Villages Program** in the Union Budget for FY 2022-23.
- It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme for comprehensive development of the select villages in 46 blocks in 19 districts of abutting northern border in the States of Arunachal Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Uttarakhand and UT of Ladakh.
- The policy aims to re-populate and reverse migration from border villages in Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, and Arunachal Pradesh through improved infrastructure, access to energy resources and educational channels, and diverse livelihood opportunities.

Other Steps:

1. The government has been taking many initiatives that include expeditious construction of fencing, floodlighting and roads along its borders with Bangladesh, Pakistan and Myanmar, and construction of strategic roads along its borders with China, Nepal, and Bhutan.
2. Establishment of **Integrated Check Posts** through of the **Land Ports Authority of India**. Integrated check post at Moreh in Manipur on Indo-Myanmar border was operationalized in March 2018.
3. **Counter Drone Technology** for the border areas being tested by the DRDO. It has been tested extensively along the Punjab border and deployed at specific points.
4. **All weather roads and tunnels** like Atal tunnel (connecting Manali with Lahaul-Spiti) and other tunnels like Shinkun La (all weather road to Ladakh).
5. **Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act 2023** exempts area within 100 km of the borders from forest clearance permissions. This will expedite infrastructure upgradation in border areas.
6. The government is also cooperating with neighbouring nations like Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar and Bangladesh for joint management of shared borders.

Factors Facilitating Illegal Migration:

1. **Porous Borders:** India has a long and porous international border with Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Pakistan and Myanmar. The border passes through various natural and cultural landscapes making it difficult to fence and patrol while easy to infiltrate.
2. **Ethnicity:** The ethnic configuration of the people is similar on both sides of the borders, and it is quite challenging to discern between the Indian residents and others.
3. **Fertile Land:** The flat and fertile land along the borders support dense human inhabitation along the border. There are many habitats situated right up to the borders. Such habitats aid in intermingling of infiltrators.
4. **Social network:** The social networks created between the old and new immigrants over decades are incredibly necessary for the movement of people stealthily across the border.
5. **Political patronage:** Political parties utilise the susceptibility of the illegal migrants for their selfish interests and paybacks. For vote banks, the political parties sometimes protect the illegal migrants.

Impact of Illegal Migration in India:

Massive influx of illegal migrants has grave consequences on the nation's socio-cultural, economic and political aspects.

1. **Radicalisation and terrorism:** In the garb of migrants, hostile elements infiltrate terrorists and terror sympathisers. These people engineer terror attacks within India. They also radicalise the vulnerable population and expand their network to destabilise the nation.
2. **Frequent clashes due to lack of security:** Illicit migration has caused periodic clashes between India's residents and migrants due to fear of loss of land, culture, and identity. This leads to their loss of life and property, thus violating their fundamental constitutional rights.
3. **Political Instability:** Fight for the ownership of limited resources, economic opportunities, and cultural dominance leads to conflict between the locals and migrants. Local political leaders exploit the conflict for their political games, thus create a great divide among the people.
4. **Law and Order problem:** The inimical elements undermine the rule of law and integrity of the country and indulge in illegal and anti-national activities, such as entering the country clandestinely, fraudulently acquiring identity cards, exercising voting rights in India, and resorting to trans-border smuggling and other crimes.
5. **Loss of livelihood for poor Indian citizens:** The illegal migrants get settled in urban areas and provide cheaper domestic help. Thus, they compete with Indian citizens who migrate from villages to cities in the search of jobs.

Community Participation in Border Management

Challenges faced by border communities:

1. The people living in India's border areas face myriad problems like difficult terrain, harsh living conditions and lack of access to public amenities.
2. Frequent shelling from across the border, thinly spread-out administration and inadequate social and economic infrastructure make life difficult in these areas.

3. Concerted efforts are being made by hostile neighbours through allurements, subversion and promotion of religious fundamentalism to generate a feeling of alienation.
4. Vulnerability to actions of border criminals.
5. Restriction/control over movement by forces.
6. Fear of unknown—threat of aggression by enemy, cross border shelling, firing etc.
7. Lack of industrialisation/economic progress leading to limited job opportunities.
8. Neglect by Government being frontier areas.
9. Lack of infrastructure, means of communication, education, medical, water and remoteness.

Challenges of Border Management:

1. **Alienation of border population** due to lack of governance and other livelihood challenges.
2. Smuggling is means of livelihood for many people in bordering areas. Prevention of smuggling activities by BGF lead to a perceived feeling that they unnecessarily interfere in the means of livelihood of local populace.
3. **Lack of communication between the local people and the BGF** causing conflict/distrust. The BGF field leadership keeps minimum contact with the local villagers. Hence, a communication gap exists which is detrimental to a congenial working environment.
4. **Border Fencing and Connected Problems:** The construction of the fencing has also generated many differences between the local villagers and the BGF. Access to the farmland across the fencing is regulated. Frequent frisking and timely gate opening are irritants to farmers.
5. **Operational annoyances:** Quite often, the BGF are called upon to take tough measures for combating terrorism and insurgency. These measures sometimes, cause inconvenience and annoyance to the local people. Such sense of discontent is exploited by hostile elements to create feeling of ill will against the BGF.
6. **Inherent limitations of BGF:** The concept of community relationship, if not alien, is still not given due importance by BGF.
7. **Mutual Distrust:** Civilians consider security forces as unapproachable and harasser, Forces consider everyone to be a smuggler thus doubting their identity.
8. Overstretched deployment of security forces and lack of sufficient electronic measures.

Role of community/VDCs along border areas

1. Reporting of any illegal activities and infiltration along the border.
2. Keeping respective areas under surveillance.
3. Reporting of any abnormal activity especially in rugged terrain.
4. Reporting of subversive activity being carried out by the enemy.
5. Employed in construction of roads, tracks and maintenance of border fencing.
6. In times of peace as well as hostilities, local population can provide invaluable information regarding enemy build-up and activities.
7. Protection of villages against criminals/dacoits etc from across the border.
8. Provide guides to the Armed Forces whenever required.
9. In the difficult riverine areas, fishermen watch groups can be formed to fill in gaps existing in the surveillance cover over riverine borders, territorial waters and the EEZ.

Suggestions for Improving the Community Relations Ability of BGF Personnel

1. **Review Field Procedures:** Many of the regulation and practices that apply to the forces distances them from the common man. They can be reformulated.
2. **Training for a More Ethical Force:** Continuous motivation, incentive and monitoring will develop morally and ethically strong force. Strict adherence to code of conduct, ethical standards and integrity to win trust of locals.
3. **Developing a Community Oriented Force:** The role of the BGF in the borders areas is such that there is bound to be a difference of opinion between the citizens and the forces. The skill for adept handling of the public can only come through sustained training. The concept of 'border guarding' can be replaced by 'border management.'
4. **Strengthening Grievance redressal mechanism:** The grievance redress mechanism against the force personnel warrants a systematic reappraisal. There are cases where the field level leadership often resorts to isolation from the public by adopting escapist attitudes with regard to the grievances of the public.
5. **Community Outreach Programmes:** The local community has a negligible and at times, a faulty awareness about the role of the forces. Periodical awareness/out-reach programmes, conducting of games, etc, for the villagers, inviting them to the BOP, organising cultural shows can draw the public closer to the BGF and increase awareness.

Recommendations to Improve the Community Participation in Border Management

1. **Attitudinal change** - developing empathy towards the local communities. Consider them **stakeholders in border management**.
2. **Institutionalizing cooperation** through initiatives like **Village Defence Organisations** and **Village Development Committees**.
3. **Permanent communication** leading to better understanding; border coordination meetings, etc.
4. Carrying out **civic action programmes**, sports activities, judicious utilisation of border population grant, etc.
5. **Educating border population** about the need and rationale of the operations carried out by BGF.
6. Developing a positive image at local levels and also through media. ·
7. Respect for the local customs and habits. ·
8. Providing assistance to population in times of need/emergencies, health assistance etc.
9. No misbehaviour/maltreatment, no forced labour, no damage to crops, no favouritism.
10. Keep watch over bad characters, identify ex-servicemen and seek cooperation.
11. Learn local language, respect women folk, elderly persons. Respect the religion and local customs.

Government Initiatives:

- **Jammu & Kashmir:** Government of India has revived erstwhile Village Defence Committees as Village Defence Guards (VDG) in Jammu & Kashmir.
 - VDGs will function under the direction of the **Senior superintendent of police (SSP)/superintendent of police (SP) of the district concerned**.
 - Each **VDG** will be provided a **gun and 100 rounds of ammunition**.

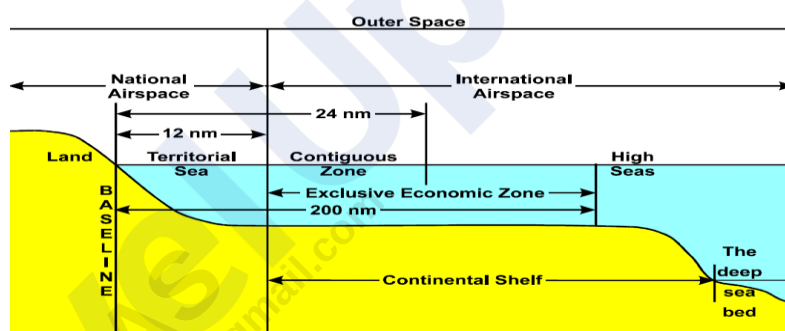
- The persons leading the VDGs will be paid Rs 4,500 per month by the government, while others will get Rs 4,000 each.
- **Assam:** Village Defence Organizations in Assam to assist the Police in the maintenance of Law and Order, peace, and tranquillity in the State.

Prime Minister's Advice:

- The Prime Minister has asked all ministries to depute senior officials for at least one night stay for a ground assessment of challenges and socio-economic conditions faced by the people living in villages facing China Pakistan Bangladesh, Nepal, and Myanmar.
- The PM also directed for expanding the coverage of NCC schools of the border areas to inculcate values of national building.
- At the DGPs' conference, he advised the police officials in border districts to go for night stay in bordering villages, take initiatives for developmental projects and keep an eye on the demographic changes in those villages.

Maritime Security

India has a coastline of around 7516 KM along the busiest Sea Lanes of Communication. It faces both traditional and non-traditional security threats like piracy, drug trafficking, terrorism and insurgency, natural disasters etc.



Present Maritime Security Mechanism of India

- In February 2009, the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) vested the overall responsibility of maritime security with the **Indian Navy**, including coastal security and offshore security.
- The **Indian Coast Guard** was made responsible for **coastal security in territorial waters**, including areas to be patrolled by the Coastal Police, and given the task of overall coordination between the state and the central agencies.
- Currently, **coastal security of India is governed by a three-tiered structure**. The **Indian Navy** patrols the **International Maritime Boundary Line (IMBL)**, while the **Indian Coast Guard (ICG)** is mandated to do patrolling and surveillance up to 200 nautical miles (i.e., **Exclusive Economic Zone**).
- Simultaneously, the State Coastal/Marine Police (SCP/SMP) performs boat patrolling in shallow coastal areas.
- The **SCP have jurisdiction up to 12 nautical miles** from the coast; and the ICG and the Indian Navy have jurisdiction over the entire maritime zone (up to 200 nautical miles), including the territorial waters (with the SMP).
- The **Border Security Force (BSF)** is deployed in the creek areas of Gujarat and Sundarbans in West Bengal.

Threats to India's Maritime Domain:

1. Adversarial powers like Pakistan and China continuously make efforts to undermine India's primacy in the region.
2. China through its **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** has tried to box India in the Indian Ocean by acquiring strategic ports like Hambantota and Gwadar. It has also been continuously arming Pakistan Navy as a balancer to Indian in the region.
3. China's overtures in the region in the form of **submarine deployment, spy ships of Yuan Wang Class** present challenge to India's idea of Net Security Provider in the region.
4. Threat of **terrorist infiltration from Sea routes** on the lines of 26/11 Mumbai attacks.
5. **Maritime disputes with Pakistan and Sri Lanka**, lack of clear boundary demarcation resulting in frequent arrest of fishermen.
6. **Illegal migrants** coming through the sea routes.
7. **Drug-trafficking** through porous maritime borders. According to latest annual report of the NCB, drug trafficking through sea routes in the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal comprise of around 70% of total illegal drugs smuggled into India.
8. **Uninhabited islands** can be used by traffickers, insurgents, and extremists.
9. Challenges like piracy, hostage-taking for ransom, armed robbery, drug-running, and human trafficking, to environmental pollution of the oceans, as also illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing.
10. **Natural calamities** like cyclones, *tsunamis*, global-warming-induced rise of sea level and resultant inundation of land areas etc.
11. **Great Power contest** in the region as Indian Ocean is the part of Indo-Pacific geopolitical construct.

Recent/Emerging Challenges

- Attacks on commercial ships in the Red sea: As India claims to be a **net security provider** in the Indian Ocean region, attacks like Houthi attack in the Red Sea become significant challenge.
- **Maritime Piracy**: Malta flagged ship MV Rues hijacked in the Arabian Sea near Somalian coast.
- **Increasing Chinese deployments in the region**: Chinese ships like Yuan Wang 03 and Xiang Yang Hong 01 have frequented the Indian Ocean.
- **Tensions with island states like Maldives**: Maldives sent Indian forces back from Maldives.

Operational Challenges to India's Maritime Security:

1. Sovereign rights and jurisdiction in the EEZ and the continental shelf complicate maritime border guarding since **sovereign rights and jurisdiction of the littoral state need to be exercised with due regard to the rights of freedom to use seas by the vessels and aircraft of other states**.
2. **Fragmented approach**: India's maritime frontiers is made up of coastlines of nine states and four union territories. Thus, **policing gets fragmented** and "**one border one force**" principle applicable to territorial borders cannot be implemented.
3. **Overlapping jurisdiction** between the IN, ICG and the SCP and a lack of unity of command at the ministry and force level.

4. **Navy and Coast Guard under different departments in Ministry of defence.** while the Army, Navy and Air Force were placed under the DMA, in a conspicuous anomaly, the ICG was placed under the MoD.
5. **Involvement of state police** in surveillance leads to mixing of law and order maintenance with maritime border guarding.
6. Other than Baseline, the terms **Maritime Security, Coastal Security, Offshore Security, and Coastline are not defined in any statutory document.** This often results in a lack of clarity in jurisdiction between the IN, ICG and the SCP.

Steps Taken:

1. Post-Mumbai attacks in 2008, an overhaul of the maritime security apparatus was witnessed with “emphasis on surveillance, intelligence gathering and information sharing.
2. **Maritime Security Strategy 2015** outlining India’s Primary and secondary areas of interest and India’s aim to be net security provider.
3. Coastal security is also reviewed periodically with all stakeholders by the **National Committee for Strengthening Maritime and Coastal Security (NCSMCS)**, constituted under the **Chairmanship of Cabinet Secretary**.
4. **Joint Operation Centres (JOC)** have been set up at Mumbai, Visakhapatnam, Kochi, Port Blair; jointly manned and operated by Navy and Coast Guard.
5. A **National Command Control Communication and Intelligence System (NC3I)** has established for real-time maritime domain awareness, linking the Navy and Coast Guard, both, at field and apex levels.
6. In March 2024, India commissioned second naval base **INS Jatayu** in **Lakshadweep**. It is also planning for holistic development of **Great Nicobar Island (GNI) Project**.
7. The Indian Navy has setup **Information Fusion Centre (IFC)** for the Indian Ocean Region (IOR).
 - The Information Fusion Centre will serve countries that have **White Shipping Information Exchange** (White-shipping refers to commercial shipping information about the movement of cargo ships) agreements with India.
 - The IFC-IOR is established with the vision of strengthening maritime security in the region, by building a common coherent maritime situation picture and acting as a maritime information hub for the region.
8. India’s **first National Maritime Security Coordinator (NMSC)** has been appointed to look into all issues of maritime security and ensure inter-agency coordination.
9. A **multi-agency group** involving **officials of IB, NCB and DRI** have been roped in to **check drug smuggling in the guise of legitimate cargo**.
10. The ‘**Sagar Prahari Bal**’, comprising 1,000 men and 80 Fast Interceptor Craft (FIC) was formed for the protection of naval bases, Vulnerable Assets (VAs) and Vital Points (VPs) along the coast.
11. **Coastal Radar Stations and Auto Identification System (AIS)** Chains have been set up for effective maritime domain awareness.
12. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has implemented a comprehensive **Coastal Security Scheme** to strengthen security infrastructure and capabilities of police of coastal states.
13. Under **Coastal Security Scheme**, coastal states/UTs have operationalized 127 coastal police stations.

14. 10 coastal police stations in various coastal states/UTs have been notified to deal with crimes committed in international waters.
15. 1382 offshore islands have been identified for their holistic development.
16. **National Academy of coastal policing (NACP)** is being setup at Mojar village, dist-Devbhoomi in Gujarat.
17. 500 satellite-based transponders are being installed on fishing boats below 20 metres of length in sensitive areas of Gujarat and Tamil Nadu for location tracking.
18. Since 2017, Indian Navy has adopted Mission Based Deployment (MBD). It has acted as first responder in crisis.
19. Under **Operation Sankalp** in the Arabian sea and the Indian Ocean Region, in first 100 days, Indian Navy saved over 110 lives, 15 lakh tonnes of critical commodities and seized over 1000 kg of narcotics.

Suggestions:

1. **Expanding Naval capability** by adding more platforms for deployment, surveillance etc.
2. Coordination between different agencies under **a single command and control structure**.
3. Engaging with **coastal communities**, fishermen so as to make them partners in surveillance.
4. **Better surveillance of uninhabited islands**, better governance of islands of Andaman & Nicobar and Lakshdweep.
5. Satellite-based surveillance, duly supported by maritime reconnaissance and AEW aircraft, and long-range UAVs.
6. **Effective cyberspace monitoring capability**.
7. Cooperating with other nations in the region for effective maritime domain surveillance.
8. Engaging with extra-regional powers to expand capabilities, cooperation, port calling etc.

Insurgency in the North-East

History of insurgency in the North-East

- The North East insurgency started within Naga hills under the leadership of **A Z Phizo**. Under Phizo leadership, the **Naga National Council (NNC)** declared independence from India in 1947. Despite the government of India's efforts, the unrest did not die.
- Representatives of hill areas merged into **All Party Hill Leaders Conference (APHLC)** in 1960 and demanded separate state within the Indian union.
- As a result, Meghalaya, Manipur and Tripura got statehood in 1972. Nagaland was granted statehood in 1963 and Mizoram in 1987.
- However, secessionist movements continued in Nagaland and Mizoram.

Current state of insurgency:

Currently, around **40 insurgent outfits** are active in the Northeast in as many as six out of the region's eight states. **Manipur has the maximum number of active insurgent groups**, while **Sikkim and Mizoram have almost none**.

According to the **Ministry of Home Affairs' Annual Report 2020-2021**, "The security situation" in India's northeastern states "improved substantially since 2014."

- The year **2020 recorded the lowest insurgency incidents and casualties** among the civilians and security forces during the last two decades.
- Compared to 2014, there has been an “80% reduction in insurgency incidents in 2020.
- While **casualties among the security forces have dropped by 75 percent, civilian fatalities have declined by 99 percent** in this period.
- In 2020, insurgency-related declined by 42 percent in Arunachal Pradesh, 12 percent in Assam, 23 percent in Manipur and 45 percent in Nagaland compared to 2019.
- Under this policy, a surrendered militant functionary is granted Four Lakh Rupees, a monthly stipend of Rs 6,000 for three years, and vocational training for self-employment. Thousands of functionaries from all the north-eastern states have availed the package over the past several years.

Insurgencies in Key States

Assam:

1. The roots of insurgency in Assam began with the protests/ agitations of the All-Assam Students Union (AASU) against the illegal influx of Bangladeshi immigrants.
2. A breakaway faction of the AASU formed the ULFA in 1979 to create a 'sovereign socialist Assam'.
3. With the signing of the **Assam Accord** in 1985, the AASU ended its agitation and constituted the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP).
4. However, ULFA continued with its struggle, with sovereignty as the prime motive.
5. The radical Islamist groups are demanding security for the Muslims in Assam.
6. The infiltration of Rohingyas has emerged as a recent matter of concern.



Bodo Peace Accord

Bodo peace accord was signed on 27 January 2020 between the **Ministry of Home Affairs, Assam government and Bodo groups** including the All Bodo Students' Union and militant outfits. It was **India's third attempt at conflict resolution** after the 1993 and 2003 accords.

Key Features:

1. Agreement to redraw and rename the **Bodoland Territorial Area District (BTAD)** as **Bodoland Territorial Region (BTR).**
2. **promises more legislative, executive and administrative autonomy under the Sixth Schedule** to Bodoland Territorial Council (BTC) and expansion of the BTC territory in lieu of statehood.
3. A **Special Development Package of Rs. 1500 Crores** would be given by the Centre to undertake specific projects for the development of Bodo areas.
4. The families of those killed during the **Bodo movement would get Rs. 5 lakhs each.**

5. A committee will decide the exclusion and inclusion of new areas in the BTAD. Subsequent to this alteration, the **total number of Assembly seats will go up to 60, from the existing 40.**

Nagaland:

1. Nagaland is home to the oldest insurgency in the North East. Nagaland attained statehood in 1963 and today comprises 18 districts divided based on Tribal affinities.
2. The first major effort towards peace was the signing of the **Shillong Accord in 1975**.
3. However, the peace accord led to **rebellion within the NNC** which led to the creation of the NSCN in 1980.
4. The difference of ideologies between the top leaders of the NSCN led to the split in the group in 1988, resulting in the formation of NSCN(IM) and NSCN(K).
5. Prolonged violence gave way to hope for peace when NSCN (IM) entered into a Ceasefire with the Government of India in 1997, followed by NSCN (K) in 2001.
6. The progress of talks between UG groups and the Government of India suffered a setback in 2015, when NSCN (K) unilaterally abrogated the Cease Fire Agreement.
7. NSCN (IM) meanwhile went on to sign a 'peace accord' with the Government of India, which apparently lays down the 'framework' for future talks/ resolution.
8. In September 2022, National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN-IM) and seven Naga groups under the umbrella of the **Forum for Naga Reconciliation (FNR)** have signed an accord to find ways to overcome differences over the ongoing peace process.

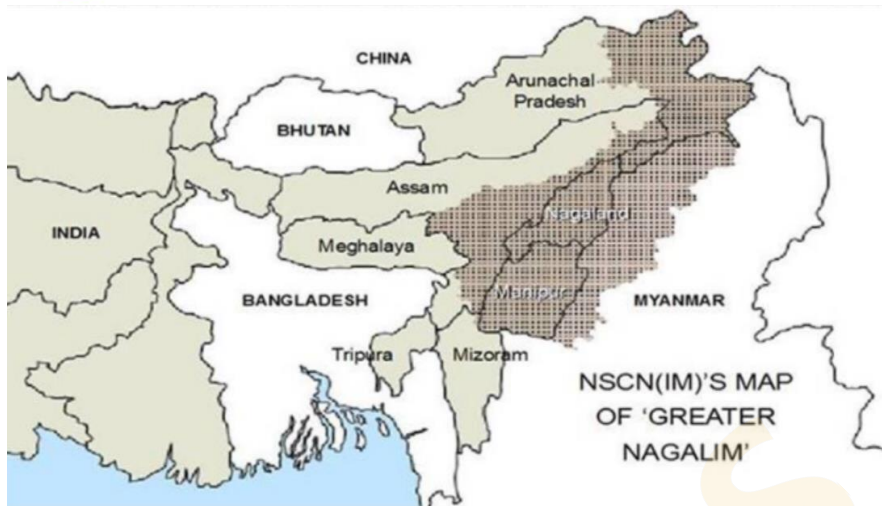
Challenges in achieving permanent solution:

- The 2015 Framework Agreement between the Centre and the National Socialist Council of Nagalim (Isak-Muivah) to finalise the Naga Peace Accord is in limbo over differing interpretations and issue of sovereignty.
- They demand for their own **National Flag and Constitution**. Earlier, neither NDA nor UPA objected to this demand. There are claims of verbal assurance over this issue.
- But with change in status of Jammu and Kashmir, situation has changed. Now the government can't afford such a demand.
- Multiple splinter groups like the NSCN-NK, NSCN-R, NSCN K-Khango and NSCN (K) Niki under the banner of NNPG is also holding peace talks with the government.
- Naga National Political Groups (NNPG) have reiterated commitment to the agreement signed with the government and in Manipur conflict, have asserted blood relations with Meiteis.
- On the other hand, Eastern Naga People's Organisation (ENPO), a body of seven tribes from six backward districts have been demanding a separate state "Frontier Nagaland" since 2010. They even boycotted Hornbill festival in August 2022, and have given a boycott call for polls.

Demand for Greater Nagalim:

- Earlier NSCN (I-M) fought for an independent Nagaland, but later on demanded a 'Greater Nagaland' comprising "all contiguous Naga-inhabited areas", along with Nagaland.

- It included several districts of Assam, Arunachal Pradesh, and Manipur as also large tracts of Myanmar.



- Nagaland Assembly has endorsed the greater-Nagalim demand "Integration of all Naga- inhabited contiguous areas under one administrative umbrella" - as many as five times: recently in July 2015.
- The Map of "Greater Nagalim" has about 1,20,000 sq km, while the state of Nagaland consist of 16,527 sq. km.
- Assam, Manipur and Arunachal always remain wary of a peace settlement that might affect their respective territories

Insurgency in Mizoram

1. Insurgency in Mizoram, at present, is peripheral in nature and comprises of the agitations by the Brus or Reangs and the Hmars.
2. Brus were forced out of Mizoram in 1997, following atrocities on them. Approximately 35,000 Bru refugees are presently lodged in temporary camps in Kanchanpur sub-division of North Tripura.
3. Due to delays in settlement of their issues by the Mizoram government, militant outfits like the Bru Liberation Front of Mizoram (BLFM) and Bru National Liberation Front (BNLF) emerged.
4. Repatriation of the refugees is presently in progress in a phased manner.

Bru Resettlement Issue:

1. In January 2021, an agreement was signed by the centre, State governments of Mizoram and Tripura and Bru representatives to allow they permanent settlement of remaining 32,000 Brus in Tripura.
2. Under the agreement, the Centre has announced **a special development project** with funding of Rs 600 crore. Each resettled family will get an estimated 0.03 acres (1.5 gandas) of land for building a home, Rs 1.5 lakh as housing assistance, and Rs 4 lakh as a one-time cash benefit for sustenance, a monthly allowance of Rs 5,000 and free rations for two years from the date of resettlement.
3. This resulted in protests from Bengali and Mizo groups in Tripura on account of resettlement resulting in demographic imbalance, exert pressure on local resources and may lead to Law and Order problems.

4. BY October 2022, over 4100 families had been resettled and deadline for resettlement had been extended to February 2023.

Various Agreements Signed to ensure Peace:

1. **Tripura:** A Memorandum of Settlement (MoS) between Government of India, Government of Tripura and **National Liberation Front of Tripura** led by Sh. Sabir Kumar Debbarma (NLFT/SD) was signed on 10.08.2019. Resulting in surrender of cadres.
2. **Bru Resettlement:** An Agreement was signed by Government of India, Government Tripura and Government of Mizoram with the representatives of Bru migrants on 16.01.2020 for permanent settlement of 6,959 Bru families (37,136 persons) in Tripura with a financial assistance/package.
3. **Bodo Peace Accord:** Memorandum of Settlement was signed on 27 January 2020 between Government of India, Government of Assam and representatives of Bodo Groups to solve the long pending Bodo issue. Following the settlement, 1615 cadres of NDFB groups surrendered their arms on 30 January 2020.
4. A Memorandum of Settlement was signed between Govt. of India, Govt. of Assam and underground Karbi groups (KLNLF, PDCK, UPLA, KPLT factions) of Assam on 4th September, 2021 at New Delhi to end the decades old crisis. With the signing of this agreement, over 1000 cadres of Karbi armed groups have abjured violence and joined the mainstream of society.

Steps taken to tackle insurgency:

1. **16 insurgent organizations** of NE States have been declared "unlawful associations" and/or "terrorist organizations" under **Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967**.
2. The Central Government scheme for reimbursement of **Security Related Expenditure (SRE)** for the States seriously affected by insurgency since 1995. The scheme is being implemented in all NE States **except Mizoram and Sikkim**. Under the scheme, fund is shared between Centre and State in the ratio of 90:10 on expenditure incurred by NE States on various security related items
3. Finance Ministry announced the execution of several rail, road, air and water connectivity projects worth Rs. 1,34,200 crores in the northeast.
 - a) 4,000 km of roads, 20 railway projects for 2,011 km, 15 air connectivity projects are being developed.
 - b) National Waterways (NW)-1 on the Ganges, NW-2 on Brahmaputra and NW-16 on Barak are under development to provide better connectivity.
 - c) **Riverine and rail connectivity with Bangladesh** and with other states through Bangladesh.
 - d) **KALADAN multimodal project, Asian Trilateral Highway** to connect region with **ASEAN nations**.
4. **North Eastern Region Power System Improvement Project (NERPSIP)** to strengthening of Intra - State Transmission and Distribution systems.
5. **Prime Minister's Development Initiative for North East (PM-DevINE)** announced in Union Budget 2022-23. This will fund infrastructure in the spirit of PM Gati Shakti, and social development projects based on felt needs of the North-East.

6. **Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER)**
7. **UDAAN Scheme** to bring North-East on the aviation map of India. The region connected with rest of India through Railways and Airways.
8. **North-East Industrial Development Scheme (NEIDS)** to promote employment in the North East States by incentivizing primarily the MSME Sector.
9. **National Bamboo Mission**
10. **North Eastern Region Vision 2020:** The document provides an overarching framework for the development of the North-East region to bring it at par with other developed regions under which different Ministries, including the Ministry of DoNER have undertaken various initiatives.
11. **Digital North East Vision 2022:** It emphasises leveraging digital technologies to transform lives of people of the north east and enhance the ease of living.

Cross Border Cooperation for tackling insurgency:

1. Since coming of Awami League government led by Sheikh Hasina to power in January 2009, Bangladesh has reversed the policy of supporting insurgents and is taking action against Indian insurgents' groups who have been using Bangladesh territory. It may face challenge now with her ouster.
2. **BSF and BGB** Cooperate on tackling cross border insurgency.
3. There has been cooperation with Myanmar military for tackling insurgency. **Operation sunrise I & II** have been jointly launched to target insurgents on respective sides of the borders.
4. The Bhutan government launched military operations against the **United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA)** and **Bodo militant camps** located in the country in 2013.

Challenges in tackling insurgency in North-East:

1. **Terrain-** Hilly terrain with dense forests Max actions by the security forces very tough. Meanwhile giving opportunity to other insurgent groups to hide and run away.
2. **Support of neighbouring nations:** vested interests in Bangladesh, Myanmar and China have supported these groups by supplying weapons and accommodation within their territories.
3. **Multiple ethnic identities-** multiplicity of ethnic groups makes it challenging to emerge as the common identity based on respective states.
4. **Influx of illegal migrants** along with fear of getting marginalised further leads to formation of such groups in order to defend their respective interests.
5. Lack of economic development and job opportunity pushes youth towards this groups.
6. Poor state of infrastructure and connectivity makes it further difficult to take swift action against these groups.
7. Limited capacity of this small north eastern states further creates challenges in ensuring peace and stability in the region.
8. Allegations of human rights violations by the armed forces and paramilitary Leads to discontent among common population.
9. High level of corruption impedes the implementation of social and economic development initiatives.

Assam-Meghalaya Border Dispute:

In March 2022, the chief ministers of Assam and Meghalaya signed a pact in the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah to resolve part of their five-decade-old boundary dispute. Over the years, the 884-km border between the two states has witnessed frequent flare-ups.

History of Dispute:

1. 1970: Meghalaya was carved out of Assam as an autonomous State.
2. 1972: Meghalaya became a full-fledged State based on the Assam Reorganisation (Meghalaya) Act of 1969.
3. The Meghalaya government refused to accept it because the Act followed the recommendations of a 1951 committee that had recommended to transfer areas of the present-day East Jaintia Hills, Ri-Bhoi, and West Khasi Hills districts of Meghalaya to the districts of Assam.
4. After claims and counter-claims, the dispute was narrowed down to 12 sectors based on an official claim by Meghalaya in 2011.
5. 2011: The Meghalaya Assembly passed a resolution for central intervention and the constitution of a boundary commission. The Assam Assembly retaliated with a resolution to oppose the move.
6. The Centre then intervened and made the two governments appoint nodal officers to discuss the boundary dispute.
7. 2019: The Meghalaya government petitioned the Supreme Court to direct the Centre to settle the dispute but the petition was dismissed.

As of now, there are 12 points of dispute along their borders. These include the areas of Upper Tarabari, Gazang reserve forest, Hahim, Langpih, Borduar, Boklapara, Nongwah, Matamur, Khanapara-Pilangkata, Deshdemoreah Block I and Block II, Khanduli and Retacherra.

In first phase, six disputed sectors have been resolved. The disputed sectors are Tarabari, Gizang, Hahim, Boklapara, Khanapara-Pilangkata, and Ratacherra under the Kamrup, Kamrup (Metro), and Cachar districts of Assam and the West Khasi Hills, Ri-Bhoi and East Jaintia Hills districts of Meghalaya.

For rest of the disputed areas, the negotiations are going on between both governments.

Manipur Violence

Current Status: PM Modi in Rajya Sabha said that violence in Manipur is continuously declining and educational institutes along with businesses have opened in most parts of the state.

According to government figures, as of 3 May 2024, 221 people have been killed in the violence and 60,000 people have been displaced. There are sporadic conflicts and violence between insurgent groups.

The state has a long history of mutual suspicion between ethnic groups in the Imphal valley and its surrounding hills.

Composition of Manipur:

Meitei: 53% of state population, live mostly in Imphal valley (10% of state area) Irrespective of party in power, the government in Manipur has been dominated by Meiteis.

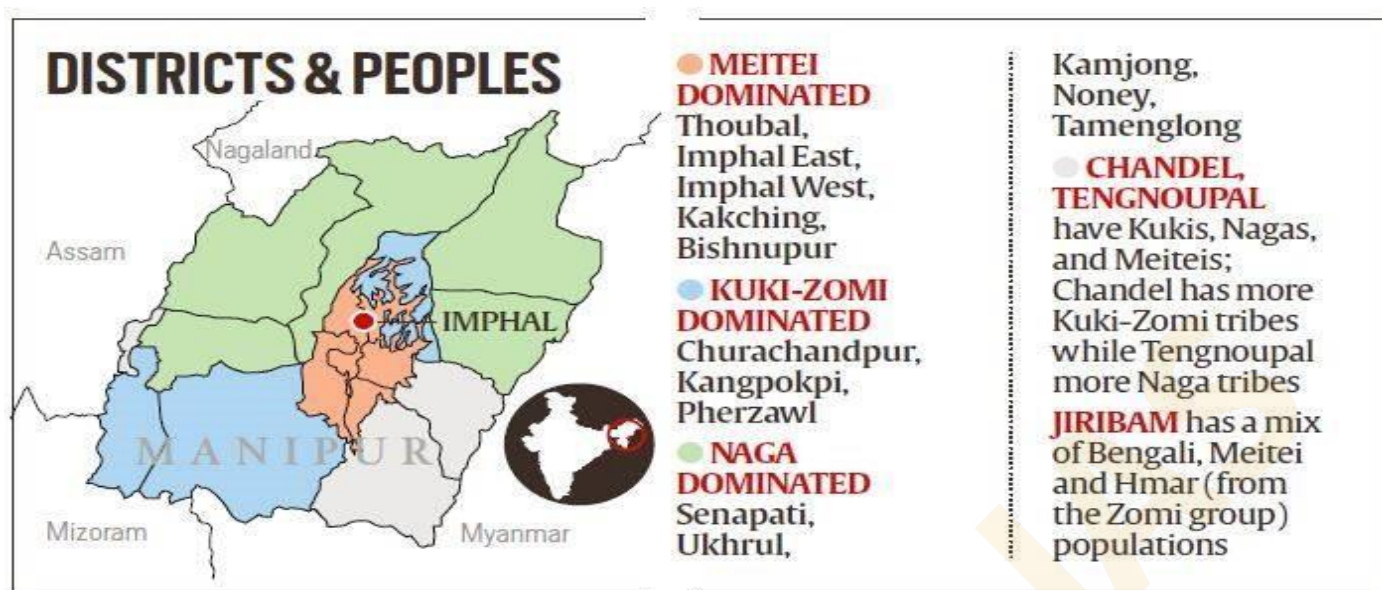
Nagas and Kukis: Up to 40% of population. Live mainly in the hills surrounding the valley.

Series of Events:

- **Demand for Tribal status by Meiteis:** Meitei community has demanded Scheduled Tribe status. The Manipur High Court directed the state government to recommend to the Union tribal ministry to grant St status to the Meitei community by 29th May.
- **Tribal Solidarity March against order:** Manipur HC order triggered protest with thousands of people participating in Tribal Solidarity March called by All Tribal Student Union Manipur (ATSUM) in all ten hill districts of Manipur to oppose the demand for inclusion.
- **Eviction drive in reserved forests by state government:** Was seen as another anti-tribal move, accentuated the widespread discontent among Kuki and other tribal groups, who had villages in reserved forest areas.
 - **Tribals:** Encroachment on tribal lands in the name of reserved forests and wildlife sanctuary. In lieu of eviction, no suitable compensation is being provided.
 - **Government:** State will not compromise in protecting government's forest resources and eradicating poppy cultivation.
- **Concern over illegal migrants:**
 - Large scale influx of immigrants caused a sense of fear among the people, mainly the Meiteis and Nagas. But Kukis became unhappy after the state government formed a cabinet sub-committee for detection of illegal migrants.
 - Government has taken tough stance against Chin illegal migrants from Myanmar, fleeing violence and persecution. Chins are kin of Kukis.
 - Meitei students' groups have demanded NRC in the state of Manipur and drive out illegal migrants.
- **Land Issue:** As population increased in tribal villages, they spread out to surrounding forest areas, which they consider as historical and ancestral rights. Meiteis are angry because they are not allowed to buy land or settle in the hill area, while tribal people can buy land in the valleys.
- On April 11, three churches were demolished in Imphal's tribal colony for being illegal construction on the government land.
- The Kuki militant groups have been in a Suspension of Operations (SoO) agreement with the government since 2008, but in the last 15 years, there has been no serious attempt at their rehabilitation. There are reports that these groups continue with fundraising and extortion.

Government position over violence: State government has said that Myanmar-based drug lords and opium growers, who suffered losses due to state government "War on Drugs campaign," are behind the unrest to stop drive against drugs.

- ✓ ATSUM has rejected the government argument and has said that the government is siding with Meiteis and targeting Kukis.



Broader Concerns of different communities:

- **The Meitei**, the majority community, is deeply concerned about the future integrity of the state, with both the Nagas and the Kukis clamouring for separate administrative/territorial arrangements.
- **Naga Community**: Show greater solidarity with their tribal members in Nagaland and remain concerned about being a fringe player in the state politics.
- **Kuki Community**: Smallest ethnic group. Geographically sandwiched between Nagas and Meiteis and fear both communities. The emergence of the Kuki militant groups resulted from the need to protect the community against armed Naga and Meitei groups. Kuki leaders have demanded a separate administration for the people of hill district as lasting solution. Some groups have even called for separate state.

Challenges:

- Loss of trust in the state government since it is being seen as partisan, working in favour of Meitei community.
- Fear of violence and instability expanding to other states like Nagaland and Mizoram, engulfing the whole North-east in a new wave of instability.
- Incidences of CBI stopped from entering investigation site and women led mob preventing operations of armed forces and forcing them to release 12 KYKL cadres present challenge to the smooth operation to apprehend insurgents.
- The fragile peace that was established after signing of agreements with Naga, Kuki and other groups might unravel, and armed insurgents may start fishing in troubled waters.
- Emergence of solidarity among the ethnic groups across the border in Myanmar can deteriorate India-Myanmar ties and threaten India's sovereignty and territorial integrity.
- It can be used by China to further destabilise the region and keep India off-balance in the North-East.

- Ongoing instability in Bangladesh can spillover to Manipur and threaten the fragile peace established in the state.

Steps Taken:

- In 2022, the state government adopted 1961 as the base year for identifying illegal immigrants. For the implementation of **Inner Line Permit (ILP)**.
- Government of India and Government of Manipur signed a peace agreement with **United National Liberation Front (UNLF)** to bring stability in northeastern region in general and in Manipur in particular.

Solution:

- Need for a credible political leadership perceived neutral by all communities. The state must become the leading arbitrator in resolving differences between ethnic groups.
- Bipartisan political approach lead by the centre can help in assuaging the local communities.
- Politicians cannot ignore their individual identities but should avoid acting like ethnic activists and stoking polarisation.
- Reviving the Naga peace accord, shutting down the SoO camps and rehabilitate the cadres for their reintegration into the society.
- Disarming the cadres of different groups and bringing in civil society members to bridge the prevailing trust deficit.
- There should be a concerted push to improve the management of the Indo-Myanmar border to prevent movement of insurgents from across the border.

Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act

- Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act Came into existence in 1958 that grants special powers to Indian armed forces to maintain public order in disturbed areas.
- The powers to declare an area as “disturbed” is enjoyed concurrently by both Central government and the State governments.

Key Features:

1. The security forces can open fire after giving prior warning to the suspect.
2. It gives them powers to arrest individuals without warrants, on the basis of “reasonable suspicion”, and search premises without warrants.
3. The security forces have to hand over the suspect to the local police station within 24 hours.
4. The armed forces must act in cooperation with the district administration and not as an independent body.

Issues with AFSPA:

1. Use of excessive and disproportionate force has increased the feeling of alienation among local population.
2. There have been accusations of fake encounters and human right abuses on the security forces.

3. Some Incidences like Manipur women naked protest in front of Assam rifles headquarters have dented the image of armed forces.
4. Ex IB director **R N RAVI** has termed AFSPA as the biggest impediment to peace in the North East.

Justice Jeevan Reddy Committee in 2004 recommended the **repeal of AFSPA** and called it highly undesirable. It hailed that AFSPA has become a symbol of oppression. **Second ARC** has also endorsed these recommendations.

Supreme Court constitutional bench in Naga peoples movement of human rights Vs. Uoi case 1997-

1. The bench unanimously upheld the law.
 2. It said that the deployments can be permitted for a temporary period. And until a situation of normalcy was restored.
 3. While declaring a region as disturbed area, the opinion of state government must be taken and there must be a periodic review of this situation.
 4. The officers of the armed forces shall use minimal force required for effective action.
 5. Any complaint about misuse or abuse of power shall be thoroughly enquired into. If allegations are found to be correct, the victim should be suitably compensated and action should be taken against the guilty.
- In 2016 case related to fake encounters in Manipur, the court held that the security personnel do not enjoy absolute immunity. It called for probe into 1528 cases of extrajudicial killings by security forces in Manipur during 2000-12.
- Recently AFSPA Act has been withdrawn from parts of Assam, Nagaland and Manipur. So, AFSPA remain in force in parts of Assam, Nagaland, Manipur and Jammu & Kashmir.
- Tripura revoked the Act in 2015 and Meghalaya was under AFSPA for 27 years, until it was revoked by the MHA from 1st April 2018.